snap up most of the fish, but they smilingly make room for retail fisherwomen and the occasional housewife. Dealings are entirely in cash and scrupulously honest. At the bottom of the food chain are women who help buyers to carry the fish from the docks to the gate in baskets that are perfectly balanced on their heads.

Over the years, many of these women have become friends. Spotting me from a distance, one or the other invariably finds me and takes me under her wing – helping me identify the freshest fish, bargain a little, and then carry the morning's purchases to my car. Helped with a little seed capital and encouragement, a few of them have started tiny businesses, buying some fish at the market and selling it to regular customers in the vicinity before heading home. It has been a joy to see their confident smiles as they have embarked on the path to entrepreneurship.

A few days after we returned from Delhi, I went to the docks. The impact of demonetization was audible in the uncharacteristic silence there, and visible in the weary desperation in the eyes of Malti, one of my women micro-entrepreneur friends.

She summed up the economic impact of the note ban in simple words: 'Every morning, I invest ₹1,000 to buy fish at the auction. During the day, I sell the fish for about ₹1,200–1,300. The profit of ₹200–300 feeds my family. And the next morning, I go back and invest ₹1,000 again to buy the next day's fish. When the note ban hit us, I was stuck with the fish for two days with no buyers and no place to store it. I not only lost my income; I lost my capital, and after a few days, all my savings too.'

The devastating human impact of India's 2016 demonetization has been narrated in the previous chapter. Insofar as the economic impact of the demonetization was concerned, the government reluctantly acknowledged there had been some limited impact, but that this was, and would remain, only transient. Economists, both in India and abroad, had differing views on this matter, and indeed the long-term